Lingua inglese

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MODAL VERBS

1. Can, could and (be) able to
2. Must and can’t
3. May and might
4. Have to and must
5. Must, mustn’t and needn’t
6. Should

Can, could and (be) able to

We use **can** to say that something is possible or allowed, or that somebody has the ability to do something. We use **can** + *infinitive* (**can do** */* **can see** etc.)

I **can** speak four languages.

We **can** see the mountains from our window.

Can you come to visit us?

I **can't** come to the party.

Can, could and (be) able to

We can also say that somebody **is able to** do something, but **can** is more usual.

We are **able to** see the mountains from our window.

Sometimes **could** is the past of **can**. We use **could** especially with: **see, hear, smell taste, feel, remember, understand**

My grandfather **could** speak Chinese.

I **could** smell gas.

We **couldn't** hear anything.

Must and can’t

We use **must** to say that we believe something is certain.

You’ve been travelling all day. You **must be** exhausted.

Carol **must get** very bored in her job. She does the same thing every day.

We use **can’t** to say that we believe that something is not possible.

You’ve just had lunch. You **can’t be** hungry already.

They have just moved into this house. They **can’t know** many people in the neighbourhood.

May and might

We use **may** or **might** to say that something is a possibility.

It **may** be true. *or* It **might** be true. (=perhaps it is true)

She **might** know. *or* She **may** know.

It **may not** be true. or It **might not** be true.

We also use **may** or **might** to talk about possible actions or happenings in the future.

Take an umbrella with you. It **might** rain later. (=perhaps it will rain)

Liz **may not** go out tonight. She isn't feeling well. (=perhaps she will not go out)

May and might

Compare **will** and **may/might**:

I**’ll** be late this evening. (for sure)

I **may/might** be late this evening. (possible)

Have to and must

Have to do something = it is necessary to do it, one is obliged to do it.

You can't turn right here. You **have to** turn left.

George can't come with us this evening. He **has to** work late.

My grandmother **has to** wear glasses for reading.

We use **do/does/did** in questions and negative sentences.

Do you **have to** work late today?

I **don't have to** wear glasses.

Did you **have to** leave early? But: I **had to** leave early.

Have to and must

Must is similar to **have to**.

We can use **must** to give our opinion (to say what we *think* is necessary, or to recommend someone to do something). **Have to** is also possible.

I haven't spoken to Joe for ages. I **must** phone him. (= I say this is necessary)

Joe is a really kind person. You **must** meet him. (= I recommend this)

Have to and must

We use **have to** (*not* **must**) to say what someone is *obliged* to do. The speaker is not giving his/her opinion.

I **have to** work from 8.30 to 5.30 every day. (a fact, not an opinion)

We cannot use **must** to talk about the past.

We **had to** leave early. (*not* we **must**)

Have to and must

Mustn't and **don't have to** are completely different.

You **mustn't** do something = it is necessary that you do *not* do it (so don't do it)

You **don't have to** do something = you don't need to do it (but you can if you want)

Compare:

You **must keep** it a secret. You **mustn't tell** anyone. (= don't tell anyone).

You **don't have to** tell him, but you can if you want to.

Must, mustn’t and needn’t

You **must** do something = it is necessary that you do it:

We haven’t got much time. We **must** hurry.

You **mustn’t** do something = it is necessary that you do *not* do it (so don’t do it):

We must be very quiet. We **mustn’t** make any noise.

You **needn’t** do something = you don’t need to do it (but you can if you like):

We’ve got plenty of time. We **needn’t** hurry. (it is not necessary)

Instead of **needn’t**, you can use **don’t/doesn’t need to**.

We **needn’t** hurry. or We **don’t need to** hurry.

Should

You **should** do something = it is a good thing to do or the right thing to do. You can use **should** to give advice or to give an opinion:

You look tired. You **should** go to bed.

The government **should** do more to reduce crime.

We often use should with **I think / I don't think / Do you think …?:**

I don't think you should work so hard.

Do you think I should apply for this job?

Should

You **shouldn’t** do something = it isn’t a good thing to do:

You **shouldn’t** believe everything you read in the newspapers.

Should is not as strong as **must** or **have to**:

You **should** apologise. (= it would be a good thing to do)

You **must** apologise. / You **have to** apologise. (= you have no alternative)

THANK YOU FOR YOUR ATTENTION!

MODAL VERBS

Task 1

Fill in the gaps with *can, could, must, can't,* or *may/might.*

1) Speak up! I _____ hear you.
2) You haven't eaten all day. you _____ be hungry.
3) You've just drunk your tea. You _____ be thirsty.
4) Peter _____ swim very well. He spent half of his childhood in the swimming pool.
5) Perhaps Maggie is in her office. She _____ be there.
6) Tom _____ read when he was 5.
7) It's so dark in here. _____ you see anything?
8) Lara gave me her phone number. I _____ have it somewhere.
9) I've heard something about Susan, but it _____ be true.
10) As a child I _____ do whatever I wanted.

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Task 2

Underline the appropriate modal in the following sentences.

1) You look tired. You *can / should* take a rest.
2) You *mustn't / needn't* speak loudly in the library.
3) We *needn't / couldn't* hurry. We've got plenty of time.
4) Peter *can / has to* work every day from 8 to 5.
5) We *can / must* eat lots of vegetables to stay healthy.
6) *Have to / May* I help you?
7) You *shouldn't / need* write to her.
8) I *musted / had to* leave the party early.

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KEY

Task 1

1) can’t
2) must
3) can’t
4) can
5) may/might
6) could
7) can
8) must/might
9) may/might
10) could

Task 2

1) should
2) mustn’t
3) needn’t
4) has to
5) must
6) May
7) shouldn’t
8) had to

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MODAL VERBS

Read the following conversations and circle the modal verbs.

Underline the phrases that:

- **ask for advice**
- **give advice**
- **express polite requests and answers.**

1.

Lucy: I got a dress from my mum but I don't really like it. What do you think I should do?

Carol: If I were you, I'd tell her. It might be an idea to go together to the shop and try to exchange it to another one.

Lucy: That's a good idea.

2.

Sue: Ann, is there any chance I could borrow your iron today. Mine is broken, and I won't have time to buy a new one until Saturday.

Ann: Sure. When do you want to pick it up?

Sue: Well, I couldn't ask you to drop it at my place, could I? It's just that I have to be at home all evening. I'll be waiting for a delivery.

Ann: Fine, I can drop it round this evening. Then, why don't you order a new iron online?

Sue: Great idea! However, I'll need yours today. We are going out tonight, and I need to iron my favourite dress.

Ann: OK. But would it be possible for you to return it tomorrow?

Sue: Yes, of course.

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